had celebrated: for once it wasn't just me who had trouble holding back tears. I was so pleased that I had so many people who mattered to me there, watching at Old Trafford, that afternoon. As well as my parents, who sat outside because that's how they prefer to watch games, I'd taken a box for Tony and Jackie and Brooklyn, and also for the American R&B singer, Usher, who'd come as my guest. When Sven first took over as England manager, he wasn't happy about music being played in the dressing room before games. He'd put a stop to it, in fact. The players had worked on him, though, and I think he came to realize how positive a part of our preparation it could be. And Usher, that year, was always on the CD player before kick-off. He had a new album out in the summer of 2001, called '8701', and had come over to England to promote it. He'd got a message through that he'd like to meet me and I'd invited him along to Old Trafford. I was a big fan of Usher—I still am—and I met him in the players' lounge afterwards:

'David, David: that's the most amazing thing I've ever seen.'

I got him a signed shirt, we had photos taken, the works. He was lucky. If you were going to watch a soccer match for the first time, you couldn't have got a much more dramatic one than that game against Greece. Meeting Kirsty, the game itself, my goal, being with my family and Usher afterwards: all that was great. One other moment from the day will always stick with me too. To get to the players' lounge, I had to walk along the side of the field, past where the old tunnel at Old Trafford used to be. The press working area is just there, to the left as you climb up the stairs, and there were still a couple of dozen soccer writers sitting, working on their reports. As I walked past, one of them stood up and started clapping. The next thing I knew, they were all on their feet and giving me a round of applause. That's something that never happens. Thinking back to after France 98, it's certainly not something I'd have ever imagined happening to me. I hope those guys know how good they made me feel that afternoon.

Usually, the English press takes some pleasing. Not as much as Alex Ferguson, though. When we got back to Carrington, the manager's first words to me were:

'I hope you're going to work bloody hard now that you're back at United.'

I knew better than to be surprised by the boss but that comment hurt a bit anyway. I came back into training on a high, all of our England players did. And, because of that, I couldn't wait for the next game for my club. I enjoy